For vaginal candidiasis (usually *Candida albicans*), clotrimazole vaginal tablets (pessaries) work like this:

1. Local delivery: The tablet dissolves in vaginal secretions and releases the drug directly onto the infected mucosa. Very little is absorbed into the blood, so systemic effects are minimal.
2. Enzyme inhibition: Clotrimazole inhibits fungal lanosterol 14-α-demethylase (a CYP450 enzyme).
3. Ergosterol depletion: Lanosterol cannot be converted to ergosterol, the key sterol in the fungal cell membrane. Toxic methylated sterols build up instead.
4. Membrane damage: The membrane becomes leaky and loses its normal function, so cell contents leak out and growth stops. The effect is fungistatic at low concentrations and fungicidal at high concentrations.
5. Result: The *Candida* burden falls, which relieves itching, burning, and the thick white discharge.

Why it suits the vagina: Human cells use cholesterol rather than ergosterol, so the drug targets the fungus with little harm to host cells.